

Forgiveness

סְלִיחָה

selichah · seh-lee-CHAH · forgiveness

RASHI

Turn toward God

Rashi reads this as forgiveness that God has not delegated to an angel. The prayer directs us toward God, where divine pardon is sought.

[Commentary on Psalm 130:4](#)

MEIRI

A reason to try

If repentance could never help, a person might give up after doing wrong. The promise of forgiveness keeps failure from becoming a reason for despair.

[Commentary on Psalm 130:4](#)

[Psalm 130:4](#)

כִּי־עָמַד הַסְּלִיחָה
לְמַעַן תִּוָּרָא

*“But with you there is
forgiveness, so that we
can, with reverence, serve
you.”*

NIV

IBN EZRA

Hope can spread

When others hear that a sin has been forgiven, they may turn back too. One person’s forgiveness can encourage another person to change.

[Commentary on Psalm 130:4](#)

MALBIM

Mercy inspires awe

A ruler may use punishment to make people afraid. Malbim sees God’s greatness revealed in forgiveness itself. Mercy can awaken reverence.

[Commentary on Psalm 130:4](#)

READ AND REFLECT

1. Why might being forgiven deepen reverence?
2. Whose example has helped you believe that change is possible?
3. Does forgiveness make you more accountable, or less? Why?

FURTHER READING

Rabbi Jonathan Sacks · [The Birth of Forgiveness](#)

Psalm 130 · [Read the whole prayer](#)